

**COVER STORY****LEADERSHIP FOR THE
21ST CENTURY****CHANGING THE WORLD**

The youth have the power

**"Let us all take that
one small step"****KANIMOZHI KARUNANIDHI** DMK MP

I would want a world free of wars, violence, poverty and fear. I would want freedom from hunger and illiteracy for the millions of children in the world. Freedom from inequality, suppression and lack of opportunity—sometimes even the lack of opportunity to live just because you belong to the wrong gender.

This century has witnessed a lot of changes—the rise and fall of Nazism, the creation and transformation of Communism. Now we are witnessing the shift of power from the West to the East. Today, the world has come to believe that democracy is the only way to go, but does democracy or development have any meaning if it does not remove inequality? Does growth mean anything when a UNESCO report says that India has the single largest number of new born deaths in the world—out of 9.7 million child deaths annually, one-third occur in India—when a large section of society is still barred from entering places of worship and denied entry into the streets of caste Hindus, and when Dalit children are prohibited from fetching drinking water from street taps?

Can we change all this? On a positive note, I would like to give a true story. Devapriyam is the director of Anavaram Trust, a rural development organisation that undertook relief efforts when the Tsunami struck the coast of Tamil Nadu. After the Tsunami, initially, most rehabilitation aid was given to men, who received fishing boats. Soon they focused on women. In one highly successful joint venture, Dalit women have come to own 30-ft fishing boats, which they now rent out to local fishermen. Earlier they used to work as labourers but now they are owners.

So this small step has gone a long way in the coastal villages where women were suppressed. A small step has changed their lives, has brought economic and social change in that village. So why can't we change the world? I am sure we can and let us all take one small step.

**"What the poor want is
opportunity, not a dole"****VIKRAM AKULA** CEO, SKS MICRO FINANCE

If I could change the world, I would end poverty. While we have many problems in India, the scourge of poverty is the largest. Sample this: 77 per cent of our people—836 million—live and earn less than Rs 20 a day. I would try to get people who benefit from economic growth. I would try to get people to live the life of a poor person for one day. What they need and want is an opportunity. It is not about a dole or a handout, it is about enabling swaraj, to give him or her an opportunity to make a better life for themselves. We do that every day at my organisation, SKS Micro Finance where we provide loans and insurance to poor people—not at a subsidised rate, but at market rates to give them an opportunity. And we do it without the government's support.

The possibilities to change the world are endless. For the government, it means harnessing the energy of the private sector and civil society to make these opportunities available for everybody. For a corporation, it is about making available their product or service to the poorest among us. For an individual, it is about making a clear choice that is not solely focused on money but also on making a difference. This morning I had a meeting with the CEO of a mobile device provider and our focus was: how to develop applications on a mobile device that are useful to the poor. And I would recruit staff. We have 7,000 people across the country—from B-schools who are willing to make the financial sacrifice, in order to be in the hinterland to work amongst the poor and provide them opportunities. I am confident that this new generation is going to be able to bring about that change.